

Chapter 4

Feminist Organizational Analysis and the Business Textbook¹

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Introduction

Male dominance of business has not remained unchallenged, particularly in regard to discriminatory practices. There have been numerous challenges to workplace inequities that have resulted in important changes in employment legislation throughout industrial society. Similar challenges have developed within business education, with the growth of feminist organizational analysis (e.g., Ferguson, 1984), including women in management approaches to managing (e.g., Henning and Jardin, 1977). Nonetheless, Jacques (1996) and others (Collinson and Collinson, 1997; Maier, 1997; Martin, 1996; Martin and Collinson, 2002) contend that, business practice continues to be dominated by masculinist discourse. This is evidenced in a number of recent studies of the cultural values and nuances of organizations (cf. Bruni and Gherardi, 2002; Wicks and Bradshaw, 2002), projected images of particular companies (Benschop and Meihuizen, 2002), media images of business as a whole (Sharp, 2003), and workplace segregation and occupational identity (Greene *et al.*, 2002).

Perhaps, as Jacques (1996) counsels, we should not be surprised that masculinist discourse continues to dominate organizational realities. Pointing out, 'women in the workplace have achieved organizational prominence to the degree that they have been able to work within the norms of that organization', Jacques (1996, p. 178) goes on to ask, 'How the industrial transformation of society has interacted with gendered sex role socialization to marginalize, not women, but the entire domain of relational practice?' Part of the search, according to Jacques, is to be found in processes of social codification whereby certain activities become viewed as inappropriate to the workplace. Thus, the problem of such things as employment equity and gender identity at work 'cannot be solved by increasing the numbers of women in the workplace if both men's and women's workplace credibility is contingent upon the suppression of "domestic" and "feminine" relational practices' (Jacques, 1996, p. 179).

In the search for how certain gendered codifications develop this chapter examines three intersecting aspects of current business discourse – organizational change programmes, the development of feminist theories of organizational analysis and their respective representation in the business text.

As a number of scholars have observed, management theory of the past twenty-five years has been dominated by popular theories of organizational change (Abrahamson, 1996; Jackson, 2001; Kieser, 1997). This has reflected the widespread adoption by companies of corporate culture change programmes, Total Quality Management (TQM), Business Process Reengineering (BPR) and, more recently, Balanced Scorecard and Six Sigma programmes. The rapid adoption of each of these programmes in turn has led some organizational scholars to question their viability as mere fads and fashions (Abrahamson, 1996; Kieser, 1997). Helms Mills (2003) contends that what we are witnessing is an 'imperative' of change, whereby managers feel almost compelled to be seen as on the cutting edge of change, and thus as 'good' leaders, by adopting the newest change programme. She suggests that, despite its detractors within academia, the imperative of change is encouraged through the complex relationships between 'educators, prophets, and missionaries', by which she means, respectively, business professors, consultants, and change agents (Helms Mills, 2003, pp. 106-111). Managers make sense of their change environment through exposure to the heralded 'successes' of practices in other companies through such things as popular 'how to' books, management consultants, and the legitimacy of management training and education.

In the later regard the textbook occupies a central position within the process of management education. For most North American business students their first introduction to management and workplace behaviour is through a textbook. It is through the business textbook that students gain their first glimpse of the theorized employee. I say 'theorized' because clearly students will have some experience of employees per se but not systematic ways of viewing the employee as such. I also say 'glimpse' because recent evidence suggests that the individual has all but disappeared from organizational studies (Nord and Fox, 1996). Indeed, the notion of the (ideal) employee is inferred through discussion of various privileged behaviours and structuring arrangements. Such inferences are themselves framed in a way that encourages the student reader to see his or her self as *the manager* of the various work processes, in control of the elusive employee. It is through the textbook that a range of theories and practices are distilled and simplified as an introduction to the 'business world'. It may not be the only influence on the fledgling manager, employee or future business educator but it will be an important influence given the significance of the textbook within processes of business education.

In distilling current management research for textbook production organizational change has been one of many developments for consideration by the textbook author. Over the same period of thirty years a number of other developments in management research have vied for attention, including the development of feminist critique and the growth of feminist organizational analysis (Mills and Tancred, 1992). In this chapter analysis of 128 North American business textbooks compares the extent to which feminist theories of organization and mainstream theories of organizational change are incorporated into textbook production of 'the business world' and what conclusions can be drawn.

Gendering Organizational Analysis Revisited

The 1992 edited collection, *Gendering Organizational Analysis* set out to reveal the gendered character of organizational analysis. Through selected previously published texts and new contributions, the collection presented a picture of organizational analysis as malestream, framed by a masculinist view of reality, in a field dominated by male researchers, and male oriented research. The collection documented the 'sex structuring of organizations'; 'sex power differentials' and the problem of organizational research; the marginalization of the female researcher; the 'neglect of gender' in organizational research; 'sex' as an organizational problematic; the relationship between organization, gender and culture; work and 'sex-role spillover'; state bureaucracy and gender discrimination; women and masculinist perceptions of management and managing; masculine bias and merit; and women and cultures of resistance. Moving beyond feminist accounts focussed on dichotomous notions of women and men in organizations, the collection included chapters dealing with issues of post-feminism and race. The primary aim of the collection was to contribute to a growing body of feminist organizational analysis that was forcing a rethink of the field.

This retrospective seeks to assess developments within organizational analysis over the last twenty-five years. In particular the chapter will examine the influence of feminism on mainstream organizational analysis, in particular the extent to which feminist research informs construction of the business textbook. Strategies for improving feminist intervention in mainstream organizational analysis are identified and discussed.

Feminism and the Mainstream

Feminist analyses of organization are not new. More than a quarter of a century has passed since the publication of Acker and Van Houten's (1974) feminist critique of mainstream organizational analysis, and more than two decades since the publication of Kanter's (1977) study of the relationship between gender and organizational structuring. Indeed the last quarter of the Twentieth Century witnessed a tremendous flowering of feminist studies of organization and a strong presence of feminist researchers within the Academy of Management and, to a much lesser extent, the Administrative Sciences Association of Canada (ASAC). In 1992 *Gendering Organizational Analysis* (Mills and Tancred, 1992) attempted to reflect and to further a field of study that had come of age.

Thus, as we review the central outlets of mainstream studies of organization and management (e.g., academic journals, business text books, etc.) we should expect to find feminist organizational analysis reflected in the comments, references and subject-matter of numerous theorists. That this is far from the case raises serious concerns and a need for review.

Gender and the Management Text

There is good news and bad news. A 1999 review of '107 widely used North American business texts published between 1959 and 1996' concluded that, 'the typical business or management text constitutes a narrative that is built around a white, male, liberal American view of reality' (Mills and Helms Hatfield, 1998, p. 37). That is clearly the bad news, especially given the fact that:

Of the 107 texts reviewed, the overwhelming majority – including 18 published in the 1990s – have little (65) or nothing (37) to say about women, gender or even sex differences. Only five texts (...) discuss the issue of gender in any depth... The majority of references to gender differences are introduced by way of discussion of employment equity legislation or the 'growing number of women in the work force' – with women being depicted in each case as a departure from the male work norm; something of note for male managers... (Mills and Helms Hatfield, 1998, p. 55).

The good news is that the majority of post-1990 business texts include 'a fuller discussion of gender', but even this is tempered by the fact that these texts 'fail to discuss the implications for understanding organizational behaviour (e.g. the effect of gender on culture, motivation, stress, communication, etc.) And even among the better texts, gender – along with race, age, sexual preference and ethnicity – is becoming subsumed under 'diversity' and problematized anew' (Mills and Helms Hatfield, 1998, p. 56).

Moreover, an in-depth analysis of six business texts published between 1992 and 1996 and widely in use in North America, found that:

Where it is discussed at all, gender is seen ... as something that strictly pertains to women and, as such, an aberration from the norm – something to be dealt with, managed, or prepared for. Nevertheless, the indexes of two of the texts fail even to include any reference to women and the remaining ones devote less than 20 out of a total of approximately 2900 pages (0.7 per cent) to discussing women. One of these works uses less than 35 lines to discuss such issues as employment equity, 'female leadership styles', the number of women in the workforce, female self employment, and sexual harassment. Another text devotes 4 (0.6 per cent) of its nearly 700 pages to discussing women and mentoring, female advancement in a bank, workplace diversity, and issues of gender and equity, leadership, negotiation and stereotyping. The two more comprehensive texts devote a little more than one percent of their pages to gender issues, but in both cases gender is equated with women, and women are equated with organizational difficulties. In none of the texts are men, males or masculinity discussed as organizational issues or problems. Employment equity, sexual harassment and workplace diversity, for example, are viewed as 'problems' associated with women (Mills and Simmons, 1999, p. 20).

Feminist Research and the Business Text

Most North American business students are introduced to specific subjects by way of a textbook. The standard textbook attempts to summarize and explain in simple

terms a range of studies, analyses and findings within the field of study. In business, commerce or administrative studies, students learn about management and organization through such diverse subject areas (and associated texts) as introduction to business, management, organizational behaviour, organizational theory and human resources management. Although textbooks purportedly address many of the key issues, findings, and debates within a field, analysis reveals that they, in fact, tend to reflect the dominant paradigm to the exclusion of others. For example, Burrell and Morgan's (1979) groundbreaking work on organizational paradigms discussed at length the contribution of a range of approaches that they went on to group under four paradigms; functionalist, interpretive, radical humanist and radical structuralist. Feminist critiques of Burrell and Morgan (1979) question the absence of a feminist paradigm (Hearn and Parkin, 1983). More recent accounts suggest the existence of feminist, postmodernist and racio-ethnicity paradigms (Mills and Simmons, 1998). Notwithstanding, the student of today will be hard pressed to find discussion of anything beyond the 'functionalist' approach in the pages of the business textbook.

To discover the extent to which feminist organizational analyses have affected management thinking, I undertook content analysis of 128 business textbooks published between 1960 and 2000. I particularly examined 100 texts published since Virginia Schein's (1973) early work on managerial sex role stereotyping.

For the first stage of the research, a list was established of key feminist works in the field of organizational analysis. The list of 57 references, constructed by a single researcher, was not intended to be an all-inclusive reference list, but rather some measure of the extent to which feminist research is cited in mainstream business textbooks. To ensure a broader reflection of feminist organizational analyses, several internationally prominent feminist scholars, who publish in English, were asked for their suggestions: 'Which, in your opinion, are 5 of the more significant feminist studies of organization/management to appear in the last 25 years?' Interpretation of the question was left up to respondents. Thirteen feminist scholars replied (five from the United States, two each from Sweden, Canada, and the United Kingdom, and one each from Finland and the Netherlands). While most suggested five article or book titles, some suggested the generic work of certain authors. Excluding overlapping references, this generated a list of eighty-four journal and book titles and fourteen named authors (see Appendix 1) to be used as the basis for tracing feminist work within mainstream business texts. Again this list was to serve only as a guide to the extent to which selected feminist work is referenced.

For the second stage of the research, the indexes of a number of selected business texts and journals were analyzed. The objective was to gauge: a) whether or to what extent (selected) feminist research is cited, and b) how soon after publication (selected) feminist research get cited in business texts.

For the third stage, a list was drawn up of theoretical approaches (e.g., population ecology, Business Process Reengineering) and specific theorists (e.g., Herbert Simon, Michael Hammer) that had affected mainstream organizational and management analysis (see Appendix 2). The goal was to track: a) the extent to

which they are referenced in business textbooks, and b) the time frame from publication of a selected mainstream theory to its referencing in a business text.

For the fourth stage, a count was done of the top five referenced authors in the indexes of each business textbook.

The last two stages allow for comparison of the textbook treatment of selected mainstream theories and feminist work in the field of management and organizational study.

Results: Positive Trends

Content analysis indicated that:

- Feminist organizational research is being cited in mainstream business texts.
- Citations to feminist organizational research are increasing in numbers, particularly since the early 1990s.
- Feminist researchers, albeit in only a few cases, do make the list of top five, referenced organizational analysts.

Table 4.1 indicates the extent to which selected feminist works were cited in business texts. In the 100 selected business texts published since 1973, citations to the work of Rosabeth Moss Kanter (1977; 1979) occur in just under half, while citations to the work of Virginia Schein (Brenner *et al.*, 1989; Schein, 1973, 1975) occur in almost one-quarter. In addition, the work of Anne Morrison and her colleagues (Morrison *et al.*, 1987) is cited in 8 per cent of business texts, Deborah Tannen (1990; 1994) in 5 per cent, and each of Carol Gilligan (1982), Gary Powell (1988) and Barbara Gutek (1980, 1987, 1988; Tsui and Gutek, 1984) in 4 per cent. A further twelve feminist studies are cited in 1–3 per cent of the selected post-1973 business texts. In two specific business textbooks, Rosabeth Moss Kanter and Nancy Adler were among the top five most often cited organizational researchers (although the references were, for the most part, not to their explicitly feminist research).

Table 4.1 Feminist Research Cited in 100 Selected Business Texts since 1973

Feminist Authors [Total number of business textbooks referencing these authors]

Kanter, 1977, 1979 [47]	Adler [3]	Hochschild [1]
Schein, 1973, 1975 [22]	Mills and Tancred [2]	Maier [1]
Morrison <i>et al.</i> [8]	Abella [1]	Martin [1]
Tannen [5]	Acker and van Houten [1]	Mumby and Putnam [1]
Gilligan [4]	Brenner <i>et al.</i> [1]	Smircich [1]
Powell [4]	Burrell [1]	Task Force on Barriers
Gutek, 1980, 1987,	Harriman [1]	to Women [1]
1988 [3]		Tsui and Gutek [1]

Table 4.2 indicates that it is becoming increasingly more likely to find some reference to feminist research in the pages of the standard business text. Although prior to the early 1980s few or no references to (selected) feminist work could be found in the pages of the business text, by 1987 at least half of all business texts made some reference, however small, to feminist research. This figure rose to around two-thirds by 1992 and has since stayed at that level.

Table 4.2 Percentage of Selected Business Text Books in a Given Period that Cite Feminist Organizational Research

[a] Time Period	[b] Number of Business Text Books Reviewed	[c] Number from column 'b' that cite feminist research (%)	
1973-77	6	0	(0)
1978-82	9	2	(22)
1983-87	24	12	(50)
1988-92	33	21	(67)
1993-98	28	18	(65)
Total: 1973-98	100	53	(53)

Compared with twenty-five years ago, the business texts devote more attention to issues of gender. At the very least then, gender has become part of the broader discourse of organizing and organization. The reasons for this are not hard to find. They include the impact of the women's movement on legislation; the growing number of women with university business degrees who are joining the ranks of management;² and, one would hope, the influence both of women-in-management organizations and the body of feminist scholarship within organization and management studies. Indeed, 'employment equity legislation' and the 'growing number of women in the workforce' are the two most referenced issues in textbook discussions of gender. Moreover, at least one more recent text has, albeit in a limited and confusing way, referenced the influence of feminism within organizational analysis:

The student of organizations needs to be an active evaluator of new theories and facts about how organization works. To this end each individual needs to understand the methods of modern science as well as postmodern approaches. These latter approaches include poststructuralism, deconstruction of texts, and feminism (Field and House, 1995, p. 666).

Limitations and Concerns

Further analysis shows that such optimism concerning the influence of feminist scholarship on the business textbook is premature. At least four main concerns must be addressed:

- The majority of selected feminist work was not cited in any business textbook.
- A substantial number of business textbooks continue to ignore gender.
- The great majority of those business textbooks that cite feminist research do so in a cursory manner.
- Business textbooks take longer to cite feminist organizational research than research from other mainstream organizational approaches.

Several key feminist works, indeed the majority of those termed 'influential' by feminist organizational analysts, were totally ignored by the authors of business textbooks. For example, Joan Acker's (1992) *Gendering Organizational Theory* one of the most referenced works by feminist organizational scholars, is completely ignored in business textbooks. And where, we may ask, is the post-feminist work of Marta Calás and Linda Smircich? Where, too, is the work of Cynthia Cockburn, David Collinson, Kathy Ferguson, Jeff Hearn, Judi Marshall, Rosemary Pringle, Stella Nkomo, and a multitude of others?

A little less than half (47 per cent) of the 100 selected business textbooks cited no feminist research. Even in the last decade of the twentieth century, then, one third of all business textbook authors saw fit to exclude any reference to feminist organizational analysis (see Table 4.2); many of those do not even reference gender, women, sexual preference, or sexual harassment (Mills and Helms Hatfield, 1998, p. 55). Indeed, in at least one case, that of Field and House (1995), reference to feminist research simply disappeared in a later edition of the textbook: Field and House, for instance, included reference to 'other approaches to organizational science' and the role of feminist research, but dropped this discussion entirely from the later edition (see Field, 1998).

In any event the citation of feminist research is extremely limited: often only a single author is cited. For instance, seventeen textbooks refer only to the feminist research of Kanter, a further six reference only the work of Schein, while one text makes reference only to the feminist work of Harriman. Thus, those twenty-four business textbooks account for 43 per cent of the fifty-three books that include references to feminist work. A further sixteen textbooks (28.5 per cent) cite no more than two of the selected feminist works. The average number of feminist citations for all fifty-three textbooks is just over 2 per textbook.

As for the impact of *individual* feminist studies on the business textbooks, only the work of Kanter (1977, 1979), Schein (1973, 1975), Tannen (1990), and Morrison *et al.* (1987) has made any discernable impression (see Table 4.1). As Table 4.3 (column d) indicates, Kanter's 1977 and 1979 works were cited, respectively, by 23 per cent and 31 per cent of all relevant textbooks (i.e., those published after the feminist work's publication date; see column c); Schein's 1973 and 1975 works were cited, respectively, in 18 per cent and 13 per cent of relevant textbooks; and the newer and less referenced work of Tannen and Morrison *et al.* were cited, respectively, nonetheless, respectively cited in 12.5 per cent and 10 per cent of relevant textbooks. Apart from the two specifically Canadian studies (Abella, 1984; Task Force on Barriers to Women in the Public Service, 1990), only Powell (6.5 per cent) and Mills and Tancred (6 per cent) exceed 5 per cent. All the

remaining feminist studies are referenced in 5 per cent or fewer of the relevant textbooks.

Table 4.4 provides a point of comparison between the citing of feminist research and that of other (mainstream) theoretical approaches in business textbooks. The table indicates that mainstream approaches fare better than feminist research. Management By Objectives (MBO), for example, is cited in more than three-quarters of all relevant textbooks (see columns c and d) Campbell *et al.*'s 'expectancy theory', Burns and Stalker's 'contingency theory', and Adams' 'equity theory' fared almost as well, with respective citations in 73.5 per cent, 71.5 per cent and 70 per cent of relevant textbooks. Organization Development (OD), Organizational Culture, and Business Process Reengineering (BPR) were cited in 60 per cent or more of the relevant selected texts. Three other approaches – Path-Goal Theory (58 per cent), Quality of Working Life (54 per cent), and Clayton Alderfer's 'Existence, Relatedness and Growth' Theory (50 per cent) – were cited in at least half of business texts, with two others – TQM at 47 per cent, and Diversity Management at 46.5 per cent – not far below the 50 per cent mark. With the sole exception of Diversity Management, all these mainstream approaches were more heavily referenced than the work of the most cited feminist scholar – Rosabeth Moss Kanter (see Table 4.1).

Even those theories that were relatively ignored in selected business texts, including Population Ecology (10 per cent) and Organizational Learning (9 per cent), are more often cited than the great majority of selected feminist scholarship. Only New Institution Theory, with 4 per cent of potential citations, comes close to the low referencing experienced by feminist scholars; even here, however, it does better than the 12 (48 per cent) of the 25 feminist studies that received citations.

In a similar vein, a considerable time lag occurs between the publication of the feminist works and their citation in a business textbook. Table 4.3 indicates that it is often several years before a feminist work is recognized in a business textbook and even then only fleetingly so. Work by Harriman (1985), Smircich (1983)³ and Brenner *et al.* (1989), for example, was quickly noted but never again cited. Mills and Tancred (1992), and Mumby and Putnam (1992), fared only slightly better, being cited once more after early recognition. The exception is the work of Kanter (1977, 1979), which, was cited relatively quickly after three and four years respectively, and often. Even the relatively well-referenced work of Schein (1973, 1975) appears to have needed six to eight years to make some impact.

Table 4.3 Impact of Selected Feminist Organizational Studies on 100 Business Textbooks Published Since 1973

[a] Feminist research referenced in Table 4.1	[b] Year of publication	[c] Potential number of business textbooks that could cite research	[d] Number of citations (d as % of c)	[e] Year when research first cited in a business textbook	[f] Time lag (years) from column b to column e
Schein	1973	100	18 (18)	1981	8 years
Acker and van Houten	1974	99	1 (1)	1998	24 years
Schein	1975	99	13 (13)	1981	6 years
Kanter	1977	95	22 (23)	1980	3 years
Kanter	1979	91	28 (31)	1983	4 years
Gutek	1980	91	1 (1)	1993	13 years
Gilligan	1982	87	4 (4.5)	1993	11 years
Hochschild	1983	85	1 (1)	1995	12 years
Smircich	1983	85	1 (1)	1986	3 years
Tsui and Gutek	1984	79	1 (1)	1990	6 years
Abella	1984	18 ⁴	1 (5.5)	1995	11 years
Burrell	1984	79	1 (1)	1998	14 years
Harriman	1985	77	1 (1)	1987	2 years
Morrison <i>et al.</i>	1987	63	8 (12.5)	1990	3 years
Gutek	1987	63	1 (1)	1993	6 years
Powell	1988	61	4 (6.5)	1992	4 years
Adler	1988	61	3 (5)	1995	7 years
Gutek	1988	61	1 (1)	1993	5 years
Brenner <i>et al.</i>	1989	54	1 (2)	1992	3 years
Tannen	1990	50	5 (20)	1993	3 years
Task Force on Barriers to Women	1990	14 ⁵	1 (7)	1998	8 years
Martin	1990	50	1 (2)	1998	8 years
Maier	1991	39	1 (2.5)	1998	7 years
Mills and Tancred	1992	33	2 (6)	1995	3 years
Mumby and Putnam	1992	33	1 (3)	1995	3 years
					Average time lag = 7 years

Table 4.4 Impact of Selected Mainstream Approaches to Organization Analysis on 128 Business Textbooks Published Since 1960

[a] Theoretical Approach	[b] Year of publication in which the approach was introduced [main author]	[c] Potential number of business textbooks in which reference could be cited	[d] Number of citations (column d as % of column c)	[e] Year when approach was first cited in a business textbook	[f] Time lag (years) from column b to column e
Management By Objectives (MBO)	1954 [Drucker]	128	98 (76.5)	1969	At least 9 years ⁶
Contingency Theory	1961 [Burns and Stalker]	127	91 (77)	1972	11 years
Equity Theory	1963 [Adams]	126	88 (70)	1963	0 years
Organization Development (OD)	1969 [French]	125	83 (66)	1973	4 years
Expectancy Theory	1970 [Campbell <i>et al.</i>]	125	92 (73.5)	1973	3 years
Existence, Relatedness and Growth (ERG) Theory	1972 [Alderfer]	125	63 (50)	1976	4 years
Path-Goal Theory	1974 [Mitchell and House]	122	71 (58)	1976	2 years
Organizational Culture	1974 [Eldridge and Crombie]	122	77 (69)	1976	2 years
Quality of Working Life (QWL)	1975 [Dickson]	121	65 (54)	1981	6 years
Population Ecology	1977 [Hannan and Freeman]	116	12 (10)	1984	7 years
Organizational Learning	1981 [Huber]	112	10 (9)	1981	0 years
Institution Theory	1983 [DiMaggio and Powell]	111	4 (4)	1990	7 years
Total Quality Management [TQM]	1988 [Juran; Demming]	81	38 (47)	1988	0 years
Business Process Reengineering (BPR)	1993 [Hammer and Champy]	43	26 (60)	1994	1 year
Diversity Management	1993 [Foster <i>et al.</i>]	43	20 (46.5)	1993	0 years
					Average time lag = 3.7 years

Tables 4.3 and 4.4 enable comparisons to be made between the time lags of selected feminist and mainstream theories. Whereas the average feminist theory takes about seven years to be cited, mainstream approaches are recognized in almost half that time. In the latter case, six approaches were cited in two years or less after their first publication; only Harriman's work comes close to that time frame. And unlike Harriman's work, all six mainstream theories were cited on multiple occasions. Nonetheless, it is fair to say that the time lag between several feminist and mainstream studies was comparable. Eleven of the former took five years or less to be cited compared with ten of the latter. Notwithstanding, it is quite remarkable that Acker and van Houten's (1974) prominent study of 'sex power differentials' took almost a quarter of a century to be noticed and Hochschild's (1983) study of emotion work took twelve years to gain one small reference.

In short, feminist organizational analysis has made some impact on the business textbook in the last twenty-five years, but the process has been pitifully slow and inadequate. To quote the reaction of a young female MBA student to a middle-aged male classmate's comment that 'women have come a long way in 40 years': she said 'I don't have 40 years'.

What Does This Tell Us And Where Do We Go From Here?

This preliminary analysis supports Jacques' (1996) contention that management education too often fails to critically engage with management practice. This is especially the case with textbook production, which occupies an important space in the process of business education. Analysis of major North American textbooks suggest that textbook production is intimately linked to isomorphism and the reproduction of safe, similar and legitimate practices (DiMaggio and Powell, 1991).

It is relatively easy to see how the process works. In the North American classroom business professors and students alike expect to use a textbook as the central reading for any undergraduate (indeed, graduate) course. Here we have normative isomorphism. There are also expectations of what the textbook should cover, and should include an introduction to many of the 'major' theories and studies in the field, which, despite Burrell and Morgan's (1979) far reaching critique, is typically defined as that which is functionalist or 'managerialist' (Mills and Simmons, 1999). Coercive isomorphism is embedded in the long established standardization of business education, which rarely allows room for experiment and change (read critical approaches to management). The standardization process has accelerated in recent years with the growing influence of the American Assembly of Collegiate Schools of Business (AACSB). This body plays a powerful role in the accreditation of business schools in the United States and Canada, with accreditation depending on the implementation of a number of standardized practices. Mimetic isomorphism comes into play as the would-be author sets out to produce a saleable textbook. He or she immediately comes up against a number of conservative forces; not least of which is the assumption that textbook learning is unproblematic. The author may have radically new ideas for a textbook but has to

get past the big publishing houses that produce most of the business textbooks. The publishers are looking for something that has the widest appeal rather than what is radically different. In the end, it would seem, it is far easier and quicker for the author to mimic the best selling textbooks in the field. Without denigrating the efforts of honest business educators, it has to be said that the pressure to reproduce a standardized text is enhanced by the fact that tens of thousands of dollars may be at stake; best selling textbook authors stand to make \$100,000 plus in a given year.

The relative absence of feminist studies of organization within the business text is, thus, not unexpected but is just part of the problem. Discussion of gender has been incorporated into a malestream discourse that tends to speak in a male voice and which subordinates humanist concerns (e.g., issues of self-esteem, discrimination, etc.) to a focus on organizational outcomes of profitability, effectiveness, and growth.

An example of male voice can be found in the text book by Randolph and Blackburn (1989, pp. 155-7). Included in an exercise that tests 'attitudes people have about women in business'. The authors state that '(t)he scores ... will provide some indication of how comfortable a person is with women in managerial positions. Since women are entering management in greater numbers, attitudes about them as managers are important and should be understood'. A more recent version of this problem can be found in the 1995 text of Field and House. The authors, despite devoting space to issues of gender, comment that:

Females are evolutionarily adapted to bear and nurture children. Besides the ovaries, uterus, and breast milk ducts, female arms have a curve that seems to make easier the carrying and breast feeding of young infants. A male arm, when displayed out from the body, palm up, is straight at the elbows whereas the female arm has a bend at the elbow. This biological difference is undoubtedly ignored or unknown by a male who when playing catch with a female says she 'throws like a girl' (Field and House, 1995, p. 2).

It is not quite clear what we are supposed to do with this information.

Part of the 'male voice' problem stems from a paucity of female textbook authors⁷ and North American business school Deans⁸ and faculty members⁹ of North American business schools.¹⁰ Indeed, in Canada, if we compare the percentage of female business faculty members with the percentage of female faculty as a whole,¹¹ the percentage of female business faculty members is lower at all ranks, except that of assistant professor. Part of the solution is the age-old strategy of working to ensure that more female faculty are hired and promoted within our universities. Part of the solution is also to encourage more of our existing female faculty, particularly feminist scholars, to take up the challenge of writing their own business textbooks.¹² As well, however, as many colleagues as possible should be encouraged to contact publishers to complain about the neglect of gender and the outmoded sexist style of today's textbooks.

But if the discourse remains focussed primarily on profitability and efficiency, the addition of more women's 'voices' will not solve the problem. Indeed, as has been argued elsewhere (Mills and Simmons, 1999), the field of business studies is dominated by a narrow functionalist or managerialist perspective. In effect, the few

feminist works incorporated into the discourse are usually made to fit, rather than question, that paradigm.

An example of the subordination of gender to business outcomes can be found in Hellriegel, Slocum and Woodman's (1995, pp. 7-8) comment: 'One management challenge is to help people understand diversity so that they can establish productive relationships with people at work. For example, Hewlett-Packard conducts workshops for all employees in which the emphasis is on educating and encouraging managers to understand culturally different employees and to create an environment that will foster productivity.' Clearly, in the absence of an influential feminist discourse, discussion of gender is being pursued within the narrow framework of 'diversity' and 'diversity management', thereby conflating a range of human needs and problems into a single 'problem' area. As Table 4.4 indicates, diversity management has become a significant discourse within management education in recent years.

As has been argued elsewhere, 'This celebration of diversity is to be applauded' rather than condemned out of hand, as '(it) certainly stands in sharp relief to the recent period in North American history when race segregation and the exclusion of women from countless occupations was viewed as normal' (Prasad and Mills, 1997, p. 5). Clearly, a number of problems with this discourse need to be engaged. For one, the discourse is centred on organizational outcomes, i.e., the celebration of diversity is secondary to bottom-line outcomes. Second, it frames gender (and race, age, etc) as a problem to be managed. Third, it lumps together issues of gender, race/ethnicity, sexual preference, age, disabilities, etc.; and fourth, it focuses the issues as a problematic for the white male manager. Nevertheless, it is a discourse where gender and race can be discussed and where feminist researchers can take issue and enter into the debate.

The unspoken question in all of this is the relevance of feminist studies to organizational analysis. Are we developing enough of the 'right kind of work to illuminate the problem of organizational development? Has the lack of 'usable' feminist research caused it to be ignored within the mainstream? Certainly a number of women-in-management adherents have been making the case for some time.

On the other hand, do feminists need to concern themselves with organizational analysis as a field of study? Isn't it, in fact, a field framed by a fundamentally masculinist bias, i.e., the dominant focus is on improving the operations and outcomes of organization. Indeed some feminists within the field have argued that organizational analysis is one of the most masculinist of the sociological specialties and therefore particularly tough for feminist scholarship to make inroads' (cf. Tancred-Sheriff and Campbell, 1992). We might also, therefore, question whether textbooks, with their oversimplification and selected distillations of a complex field of study are a viable educational tool for feminist work. It could be argued that organizational analysis encourages a masculinist style of discourse that avoids concern with feeling and an emotional attachment to selected issues. To quote Jacques (1996, p. 178), the representation of certain practices (e.g., relational practices) 'do not simply disappear. They are subject to systematic organizational practices through which they "get disappeared"'.

And, finally, assuming that feminists still feel the need to engage in organizational analysis, there is the enduring question of gender vs. women's voice (Calás and Smircich, 1992; 1996). In short, how do we combine the problem of questioning the gendered frameworks in which 'women' and 'men' are constructed with the need to challenge the impact of those frameworks on women? This issue has proved particularly problematic in textbook discussions, with their emphasis on the contributions and outcomes for 'real' or essential people. That is not to argue for an essentialist perspective that panders to the managerialist discourse; rather it is a call to reflect on how feminists can advance the political problem of equity that, to a certain extent, asks for the locating of 'essential women' in discriminatory contexts. A good example is the decision by the Women-in-Management Division of the Academy of Management to rename itself the Gender and Diversity Division. The aim was to circumvent a strong focus on women-in-management research that had strengthened the notion of essential women and, arguably, contributed to discriminatory images of ingrained sex differences. Some argued that the change would obfuscate the feminist project of 'women's liberation', by removing 'women' from the title of the new division and linking gender with the broader concerns of 'diversity'. Others argued that, in fact, the change encourages a broader concern with the intersections of race, ethnicity, and gender, thereby moving away from the narrower, more problematic concern with racially neutral i.e. 'white' women.

Notes

- ¹ This chapter has been adapted from *Gendering Organizational Analysis – A Retrospective*, which appeared in *Feminism(s) Challenge the Traditional Disciplines* (13–25). Montreal: McGill Centre for Research and Teaching on Women Monograph (1).
- ² For example, in Canada the percentage of business and commerce Ph.D. students has risen from 29.7 per cent in 1992–3 to 34.7 per cent in 1994–95 (Statistics Canada, 1995; CAUT Bulletin, 1996. According to one estimate, the percentage of middle and senior managers in Canada who are female rose from 16 per cent in 1971, to 25 per cent in 1981, and to 39 per cent in 1991 (MacLean's magazine, Oct. 4, 1993).
- ³ This was an article of organizational culture and does not reference gender.
- ⁴ As a Canadian Royal Commission Report, its contents might more likely be reported in business textbooks with a Canadian focus. On that basis, the potential referencing is reduced from 79 to 18 textbooks.
- ⁵ This was also a specifically Canadian report as well. Thus, the number of business texts that might reasonably be expected to reference the report is reduced from 50 to 14.
- ⁶ Although MBO dates back to 1954 the time lag has been weighted to take account of the lack of pre-1960 textbooks in the sample.
- ⁷ Of the 107 textbooks reviewed by Mills and Helms Hatfield (1999, p. 62) only one was solely authored by a woman, and six others had female co-authors.
- ⁸ In Canada less than five per cent of business school deans are women, an improvement on 1987 when the figure was less than two per cent (Mills and Simmons, 1999, p. 180).
- ⁹ In Canada women constitute around 18 per cent of all business professors, including 7 per cent of full professors, 16 per cent of associate professors, 29 per cent of assistant professors, and 39 per cent of lecturers.

¹⁰ This is certainly the case in Canada but may be less so in the United States.

¹¹ Women constitute 23.1 per cent of all Canadian professors; 11.1 per cent of professors, 26.4 per cent of associate professors, 56.8 per cent of assistant professors, and 40.9 per cent of lecturers.

¹² In the United Kingdom Fiona Wilson (1995) and Elisabeth Wilson (2001) – no relation – have made important contributions to this process.

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